rightist approach. Leftist thinking is not acceptable to the public in this state. They are averse to it.'[45]

The only difference between Hindutva sentiments in the Hindi heartland and Karnataka, many leaders believe, is in the public emphasis, packaging and volume of it in party communications. 'BJP is a relatively moderate party here,' observed V. Anand. 'What you see in UP is not here. Lord Ram is important here, but you don't have to live for it like in UP. Even in coastal areas, they are very vocal. They won't let you take them for a ride, but they will not be of a violent kind. That streak is there in Karnataka. We have a silent, strong community but accountable cadre.'[46]

This was not always so. The Jan Sangh won only four of 216 seats in the 1967 state assembly polls. When Ram Sewak, a Jan Sangh candidate, managed to save his deposit in the polls in 1967, such was his joy that he remembers having taken out a victory procession despite having lost the election. As he told the journalist Veeraraghav, 'Those were the pitiable days. Nobody was willing to touch us. We were almost untouchables.'[47] Even a decade later, in 1977, only nine of the sixty Janata Party MLAs were from the Sangh. The BJP then won eighteen of 224 seats in 1983 before being virtually wiped out in the late 1980s.

It was at this point that, in tandem with the Ayodhya movement in the north, a local religious dispute over a playing ground in the eastern town of Hubli proved to be a game changer. From just four seats in the state assembly in 1989, the BJP jumped fourfold to forty seats in 1994. All its leaders agree that the Idgah Maidan was pivotal here. In the north, the Ayodhya dispute had festered for over a hundred years as a localised property dispute before becoming the political flashpoint that transformed the BJP's political fortunes in the 1990s. The roots of the Hubli dispute lay in a 999-year lease agreement that the Anjuman-e-Islam (AeI), a local Muslim body, had signed with the local municipality in 1921. The lease conferred on it the right to use the 1.5-acre maidan, also called the Kittur Rani Chennamma Maidan, twice a year for prayers. The rest of the year, it was a playground for cricket and other sports, for holding fairs during jatras and public meetings by political parties. The problem began when the AeI decided to 'construct a building there' in 1990.[48] 'It was